

Claude Code Setup

FRONTMATTER

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REFERENCE VIDEOS

- CLAUDE CODE FULL COURSE 4 HOURS: Build & Sell (2026) (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QoQBzR1NIql>) -- Nick Saraev -- Watch the setup section for how he handles the API key and authentication steps; note the order of operations
- Install Claude Code in 10 Minutes (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EoGNCjQVbj4>) -- Independent creator -- Watch for the beginner-level pacing and which steps confused first-time installers most
- Claude Code Tutorial #1 - Introduction & Setup (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SUysp3sJHbA>) -- Independent creator -- Watch for how they sequence Node.js check, install, API key, and first command

THE ONE THING

Setting up Claude Code takes 10 minutes -- the only real blockers are Node.js and an Anthropic API key, and both take less than 5 minutes each to sort out.

HOOK

Installing Claude Code tripped me up the first time. Here is the setup that actually works in 2026 -- start to finish, nothing skipped.

TARGET VIEWER

Someone who just watched Claude Code Explained and wants to install it right now but is not sure where to start, what they need, or whether their machine is ready.

PAYOFF

After watching, the viewer has Claude Code installed, authenticated with an API key, has run their first command in a real project folder, and knows three starter tasks to try immediately.

BEAT STRUCTURE

Beat -- What You Actually Need

Point: Two things: Node.js (to install Claude Code) and an Anthropic API key (to authenticate it). That is the entire prerequisites list.

Visual: Clean list on screen: Node.js checkmark, API key checkmark -- then terminal ready to go

Target words: ~80w

Beat -- Check and Install Node.js

Point: Run `node --version` in your terminal. If it errors, download and install Node from nodejs.org -- takes under 3 minutes.

Visual: Terminal showing `node --version` returning a version number; then the nodejs.org download page; then the installer completing

Target words: ~120w

Beat -- Install Claude Code

Point: One command installs it globally: `npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code` -- after this, the `claude` command works from any folder on your machine.

Visual: Terminal: run the `npm install` command, watch it complete, then run `claude --version` to confirm

Target words: ~100w

Beat -- Get Your API Key

Point: Sign up at console.anthropic.com, add a payment method for pay-as-you-go access, navigate to API Keys, create a new key, and copy it. Set a usage limit while you are there.

Visual: Screen recording of Anthropic console: sign up flow, billing page, API keys section, creating a key, setting a monthly usage cap

Target words: ~170w

Beat -- Authenticate and Run Your First Command

Point: Navigate to a project folder, run `claude`, paste your API key when prompted. Then ask it to describe the project -- this is your proof of life.

Visual: Full terminal demo: `cd` into a project, run `claude`, paste key, type "describe this project", watch the output appear

Target words: ~200w

Beat -- Three Starter Commands

Point: Three tasks that immediately show what Claude Code can do: describe the project, find a bug in a specific file, write a test for a function.

Visual: Three quick terminal demos back to back -- each 20-30 seconds showing Claude Code doing real work

Target words: ~150w

Beat -- CTA Bridge

Point: You are set up -- the next video covers folder structure: the one setup decision that makes every Claude Code project easier to work with from day one.

Visual: Preview of Claude Folder Structure video

Target words: ~60w

ANALOGY BANK

- API key: Like a password that tells Anthropic's servers this is a legitimate, paying user -- without it, Claude Code has nothing to authenticate against and nothing happens.
- Global npm install: Like adding a new command to your computer's vocabulary -- once installed globally, you can say claude from any folder on your machine, any project, any time.

THESIS LINE LOCATION

Beat 5 -- The insight is: the authentication step is the only real friction -- once that is done, Claude Code is one terminal command away in any project folder you ever work in.

FRAMEWORK PHRASE

Install, auth, run

SPECIFICITY BANK

- Check Node: `node --version`
- Install Claude Code: `npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code`
- Run Claude Code: `claude` (in any project folder)
- API console: console.anthropic.com
- API key format: starts with `sk-ant-`
- Set usage limits in Anthropic console under Settings > Usage Limits

CONSTRAINTS

- Do not explain CLAUDE.md, permissions, or folder structure -- those are separate videos
- Do not go into IDE integration or VS Code extension -- keep it terminal-only for simplicity
- Primary target is Mac/Linux -- note Windows users may need WSL but do not go deep on it
- Do not show advanced Claude Code features -- just installation and first successful command

CTA DIRECTION

You are set up -- the next video shows the exact folder structure that makes every Claude Code project cleaner and easier to work with from day one.

PERSONAL ANGLE [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: A moment where the setup confused you or something did not work -- a specific error or step that tripped you up -- and what the actual fix was.

VULNERABILITY MOMENT [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: The first time you ran up an unexpected API bill without realising it -- and how you set a usage limit immediately after to prevent it happening again.

Note: belongs in Beat 4